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Culture (OWC): [Konso \(MP17\)](#)

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Sub Region: Eastern Africa

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Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1997 AD

Place Coverage

Konso Special Woreda, Southern Nations, Nationalities, and Peoples' Region, Ethiopia

Section Title(S)

8. Masculinity and "Merit" • 9. Conclusions

A question is whether normal men only practise sodomy with *sakoota*, or among themselves. They were generally very reluctant to talk about sexual matters with me and, while they may make coarse remarks on occasions, are reserved among themselves, except in the men's sleeping houses at night. When I was at Buso there was much laughter one night outside my hut at supertime. On inquiring what it was about I was told that they were joking with one elderly man, who had the reputation of being something of a *sakoota*, and saying that they would take him out into the fields and rape him. This sort of occasion, the conduct of the transvestites, and the long periods of sexual abstinence that are required after their wives have given birth, lead one to suppose that they may seek relief among themselves in homosexual intercourse on occasion. But this is not to say it is approved of, and there is no doubt that for them such a form of sexual relationship is sterile, unnatural, and hence deplorable.

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9. Conclusions

Instead of the extreme claim that every institution must have a function or be an adaptive necessity it would be more reasonable to say instead that there can be certain combinations of institutions and values that fit together well, while others are mutually incompatible. Good examples of institutional complexes that are internally compatible are to be found in those of the East and West Cushitic societies. Each of these "complexes" is internally coherent but they cannot be combined without some of their elements necessarily being relegated to a secondary position. So, among the Konso the *qallu*-type regional "priests" have a significant [234](#) resemblance to the "kings" of the West Cushitic complex, but they are not at the apex of a district and sub-district hierarchy and the clans are dispersed and have no association with land ownership. This exists only at the lineage level and even here is much weaker than in the West Cushitic model. On the other hand it is clear that a

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gada system would have little point in West Cushitic societies where authority is based on descent, and where there is only a rather weak example of elective office in the so-called "*halaka*" offices in one or two of those societies.

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